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Introduction

For this project, we chose to work on the case of Sulydance Academy.
The idea stems from the genuine fact that our colleague Daniela studied at this dance academy for 6 years during her adolescence, and as a firsthand attendee she was able to see how in a short time Suly Barrera, her teacher and owner of the dance academy, was able to manage and develop this small family business so well across the time.

Therefore, after everyone agreed to take this dance academy as a good example, we contacted Suly Barrera, who positively welcomed our enthusiasm and our willingness to help her improve the marketing activities of the business. Thus, following the demands of the project, we first began to study specifically the company's presence on digital channels, the platforms it uses, and in general the customer experience surrounding it.

However, because there were so many questions, we chose to clear our doubts and go to ask Suly directly in person.
Indeed, we went to her school to have an interview with her, who has been extremely warm and after showing us the dance academy and letting us witness a dance class of Sevillana, has been collaborative in spending 2 extra work hours of her time just to answer our questions.
On this occasion, Suly provided us with the data and metrics we needed to analyse her case and eventually, we both started approaching the goals we wanted to achieve together.
She explained to us her goals for the present and the future, the things that currently work and the ones that don’t, and afterwards, we shared with her our ideas and the goals we want to achieve in the construction of the strategy.

Therefore, the key point of this paper will be to apply the concepts learned in the marketing metrics and analytics course to a real small business case, hoping that what we have learned can be put into practice starting from today to the next few years and that Suly Barrera and her dance academy can pursue our strategy to succeed in the future.

Enjoy your reading.

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1. Company description

1.1 History

The dance academy started in 2010 when Suly Barrera Risco - owner and founder of the company - came to Portugal and made her dream come true.

Indeed, Suly was born in Cuba, and the idea of founding a dance school was in her mind for a long time: after graduating in the speciality of dance from the National School of Art in Havana in 2006, she attended multiple courses and specialization where besides studying many dance styles, she broadened her knowledge by studying Social Communication.

In 2009 she travelled to Portugal and immediately created the "Suly Barrera Dance School" - which in 2016 was renamed "Sulydance Academy".
The school, based in São Domingos de Rana, consists of a space of 200m², with 2 large dance studios of 65m² and 50m² both equipped with professional sound systems, and special floating floors (linoleum) for dancing and mirrors.
The academy offers the students a large choice with various dance classes in Ballet, Contemporary, Latin, Sevillanas, Hip-hop, Dance Fitness, and also theatre, and on occasion a pack of dance classes for the bride and groom in anticipation of the wedding.

During these 15 years, the school has had a discrete success and has achieved many national and international prizes - more than 100.
If at first, the academy was just a dance school, over the years Suly started to expand the activities of the academy.
Indeed, in 2017 they organized the first edition of the Cascais International Youth Dance Festival. Held in São Domingos, this event has become an institution in the past years and now in 2024 is looking forward to approaching its 7th edition.
Then in 2018, Suly founded the "Sulydance company", to continue the work carried out with her students and so perform on request for customers at weddings, auditoriums, corporate events and more.

1.2 Mission, Vision and Values

The mission that drives the activity of the small company is to train the new generations of dancers, contribute to their training, unlock their potential and transform them into future professionals in this industry.

The vision is to establish the Sulydance brand as a reference in the world of dance, in addition to expanding and opening more schools throughout Portugal.

The values that best represent the Sulydance Academy are:

discipline, versatility, creativity, vocation, sense of community and personalized customer relationship.

Sulydance Academy does not want to be seen as an occasional sports option by children, they want to train talents who are willing to show professionalism and constant dedication to become professional dancers or dance teachers, and potentially new resources for the academy.

Indeed, the school has employed many students during these years, by transforming them from students to teachers, and, currently, it has just got the news that one of her students, the sixth since the foundation, is going to enter the higher education school of dance in Portugal.

1.3 Customer relationships

Suly focuses on personal relationships between the teacher and the students because to her it is really important to how the students feel. Gestures like teachers giving a hug or a kiss to each student are spontaneous in all situations, but from an analytical point of view, these signs are immeasurably valuable for a small business.

She truly really cares about the students, and exactly like that, she expects every teacher to do the same, because small actions show how important having great personal relationships with customers is, and even if it might be taken for granted, they belong to the customer care processes.

Suly's attention and care guidelines with the students and their parents are paramount and overall, one of the core values of the company.

2. Business context

2.1 Global trends in the Portuguese market

According to recent data on the general global trends in the dance academy industry, there is a general interest of people looking for extracurricular activities, with dance being a popular choice, especially for young children and young adults. Many years ago dancing was an activity associated with the traditional style of ballet, today more than ever there is a growing demand for a large offer of dance styles, with contemporary, hip-hop, street dance and social dances like Kizomba.
One of the main drivers of this movement is that people are increasingly looking for activities that promote physical and mental well-being and at the same time provide the chance to have social interaction, one of the biggest desires after the pandemic *(Statista, 2024)*.

When analyzing the customers in this business it must be taken into consideration that, although many people could become potential leads, there are just a small number of them who are willing to pay. Dance lessons can be quite expensive indeed, especially for families with multiple children.
Overall, to conclude a general consideration of the global movements of this business, academies have to be aware that to enhance their value proposition they need to:

- Specialize their school with specific dance styles
- Have highly qualified and experienced instructors
- Offer flexible class schedules and pricing options
- Focus on the creation of a positive and inclusive learning environment - extremely important for children.
- Exploit the use of digital channels to reach potential new students.

Regarding the Portuguese market, we can state that the same considerations made for the global market are valid for Portugal. Of course, everything is different if we want to compare Portugal to the US or other European countries, but the trends stick with the same global path.
Additionally, it is impossible to find correct numbers of how many people dance in Portugal or estimate the value of the market, since there is no research about it, but it is quite evident how much dancing is a popular activity, and the fact that a lot of people enjoy doing it both as a social and a performance art could become an opportunity to exploit with the right adjustments for many future aspirant owners of dance academies.

2.2 Competitors of Sulydance Academy

Regarding the competitors that Sulydance has, we must consider different points of view and make many considerations.

During our interview, Suly said that she does not believe that has direct competitors.

This is because she believes that hers is a school that differs from the others, and to gain access, it has requirements such as constancy and continuity - in addition to talent - whereas in other schools, students do not have this type of criteria. Suly does not exclude any students or force them to choose different modalities but uses seduction as a tactic with the students to make them more interested in the world of dance. Especially after the shows where students get to see each other's work, it makes students want to train different types of dances.

The Sulydance Academy tries to avoid having as clients``commercial students`` who are only interested in dancing out just for reasons like curiosity, passion, fun or socialization.

In this regard, it should still be considered that even with this very specific niche this factor can be considered her main **competitive advantage**.

However, on the other hand, many students, especially children, start when they are young, and it is difficult to ask them to have an athlete's mindset at that age. Some parents for their children see sports as a form of stress relief, fun and socialization, not a real discipline that requires commitment and continuity.

Thus, even if she is probably aware of it, this competitive advantage might be a double-edged sword and so bring many clients to other more generalist schools, with a lower quality required level, and a less ambitious environment.

Having made this consideration, let’s analyze the current and potential customers from a geographic point of view.

Suly stated how a lot of students in the academy come from the same city where the school is based, São Domingos de Rana[1]. But, she also added that there are also many students coming from other surrounding cities, mentioning in particular a group coming from the city of Sintra[2].

Furthermore, most of her clients live next to the school or the closest cities. During an atypical

[1] a civil parish of the Portuguese municipality of Cascais, part of the Greater Lisbon subregion.

[2] town in the foothills of Portugal’s Sintra Mountains, near the capital, Lisbon.

situation as it was the pandemic, Suly continued the activity of her academy and offered online dance classes. In many cases, it's almost impossible to teach high-level dancing activities without a physical presence in a class with the students, but perhaps in the future with the development of technologies - Augmented and Virtual reality for instance - the geographic range of her services could become potentially available everywhere, in Portugal and not only, having only the sky as a the limit.

However, "returning to planet earth", and given the considerations mentioned before, one of the most important factors remains the physical position of the school and its distance far, but at the same time close, to the Portuguese capital of Lisbon.
Then, the Sulydance Academy's competitors are:

- EDAM, based in São Domingos de Rana
- Dance Stage, based in São Domingos de Rana
- Oeiras dance academy, based in Oeiras
- Jazzy Dance Studios, based in Lisbon
- Royal Academy of Dance Portugal, based in Lisbon
- Cascais dance academy, based in Estoril
- Sintra Dance Academy, based in Sintra

3. Marketing analysis

3. 1 Digital Marketing analysis

Although Suly addresses some of the duties to an external professional marketer for the creation of communication materials and the management of the website, she is the only person responsible for running the marketing activities, mainly on social media, but also the website.

Here we analyzed all the digital channels used as touchpoints with her stakeholders and we provided our suggestions for each of the social media and every single account used by the company. This will immediately impact the SEO of the website, and enhance the content creation on social media.

3.1.1 Website[3]

- It has a very strong visual identity.
- Specific page for the company and the festival.
- The website's language is only Portuguese.
- On some pages, it is difficult to read the sections.
- The TikTok link is missing.

Suggestions:

- We propose to have the website available in English and Spanish language. Since Suly is working on her personal brand and her main language is Spanish it would make sense to have it in this language, also because she already had Spanish-speaking students. For the English language, it would make sense not only for the international festival, since it would be valuable to the eyes of European and international organizers of dance competitions, but also because nowadays there are a lot of foreign families coming to Portugal.
- We propose to show the social media links on the main page because it is hard to find them.
- The Suly Academy also has the CID (Intensive Dance Course), which is a free course with limited places, supported by the state, which prepares students for the physical exams for higher education in dance. This information is only available on social media and we propose to have it also on the website.

[3]https://www.academiasulydance.pt/pt/

3.1.2 Social media and other channels

3.1.2.1 Facebook[4]

Δ *"Academia Sulydance"* profile:

- 4,2 mil likes/4,4 mil followers.
- The logo is different ("ASD" instead of "Academia Sulydance").
- Relevant daily organic content.
- There is only the link to the website.
- "Mirror posts", so duplicated content on 2 social media platforms (in this case from Instagram).

Suggestions:

- ➢ Keep the same logo ("Academia Sulydance").
- ➢ Repost of other institutions.
- ➢ Do not duplicate content. The content needs to be "adapted" for Facebook audiences.
- ➢ Too many Facebook accounts could be confusing.

Δ *"Sulydance SulyBarrera"* profile:

- 1,1 mil friends.
- Logo Academia Sulydance.
- The link for the website does not work.

Suggestion:

- ➢ Delete this account in order not to confuse the audience.

Δ *"Companhia Sulydance"*profile:

- 1,1 mil followers.
- Logo Companhia Sulydance.
- There is only the link to the general website.

Suggestions:

[4]https://www.facebook.com/academiasulydance/

- ➢ Change the logo to another one that people can identify with academia Sulydance, using the same type of letter and the same red as the logo of Sulydance Academy.
- ➢ Link to a specific section of the company on their website.

Δ *"Suly Barrera"* profile:

- Used as personal Brand
- 4,9 mil friends.

Suggestions:

- ➢ Same profile photo of other social media to a better recognition of the followers and possible followers.

Δ *"Festival Jovem Internacional de Dança de São Domingos - Cascais"* profile:

- 1,6 mil likes / 1,8 mil followers.
- They have a different logo for the festival.
- Link to the festival on the website.
- Very difficult to find.

Suggestions:

- ➢ Create an event on the platform with the festival.
- ➢ Description of the festival in bullet points.

3.1.2.2 Instagram[5]

Δ *Academia Sulydance* profile:

- Very difficult to find.
- 5.316 followers.
- "Academia Sulydance" is the logo (not ASD).
- Address linked.
- Link to message Suly chat on WhatsApp.
- Too many story highlights.

[5] https://www.instagram.com/academia_sulydance/

- Posts almost every day.
- Several contents.
- Different colours and fonts are used in some posts.

Suggestions:

- Adapt the logo for a better perception of the profile.
- Improve the cover of the videos.
- Use the same type of letter and the same red. Every post has a visual identity (an example of a lack of visual identity is: a Mother's Day post).
- Reduce the number of highlights and keep the most important ones that help customers find information.

Δ *"Companhia sulydance"* profile[6]:

- 284 followers.
- Mobile number but it's not linked (WhatsApp).
- There are a lot of photo collections transformed into videos.
- Link for the "Companhia" on their website.

Suggestions:

- Change the logo to another one that people can identify with Sulydance Academy.
- Instead of the photo collections, it would be better to post more Reels about dancing classes, shows, events, and overall more varied content.
- Have a linktree to have several links, such as the number of WhatsApp, the direct link for the section of the company on the website and other social media.

Δ *Suly Barrera* (personal profile):

- 1025 followers.
- Different highlights.
- Linktree with her e-book, Instagram, Facebook and site.

[6] https://www.instagram.com/companhiasulydance

Suggestions

- Same profile photo of other social media.
- Change the visual identity to be more similar to the brand without being the same, but which makes a person relate.

Δ *"Festival Jovem Internacional de Dança de São Domingos - Cascais"* profile:

- 1285 followers.
- Very difficult to find.
- Difficult name to read and keep in memory.
- Link to the section of the festival on the website

Suggestions

- Change the name to help with SEO, and consequently make the page easier to find.
- Place the original logo for better visibility.
- Leave the logo with the edition number for a post.
- Hyperlink the account @academia_sulydance.

3.1.2.3 TikTok[7]

Δ Sundance Academy

- 376 followers and 3699 likes.
- Some videos are shared on Instagram too (watermarks).
- Suly just started to use it recently and she did not believe in the power of the TikTok platform before, but it can get a very large reach through this platform.

Suggestions:

- Change the logo to "Academia Sulydance" and adjust.
- Linktree with other social media, whatsapp, mail and website.
- Post videos with fast cuts, different views, energetic videos.
- TikTok dance trends from professional dancers.
- Reaction videos for other famous dance trend videos.

[7] https://www.tiktok.com/@academiasulydance?_t=8mQCIO25QLh&_r=1

- “Show your own choreography “ videos.
- Create new # to create community.
- The duplicate content on social media platforms is not efficient, better adapt or create new one.

Δ *Suly Barrera* personal brand:

- 170 followers and 840 likes.
- Suggestions
- Same profile photo of other social media.

Suggestions

- Do not publish videos with a watermark from other social networks, as this prevents you from having good engagement as it goes against the algorithm.

3.1.2.4 YouTube[8]

- They do not share videos frequently this year.

Suggestions:

- It would be a good platform to share full shows and live-streaming.
- Share videos about events, classes, the community, and some other types of content, like “how-to” videos, “main mistakes that beginners do” etc…
- Change the AASD to ASD.
- Videos about shows, and longer trailers, events, classes, the community, “how-to” videos, “main mistakes that beginners do
- Parents would share on social media platforms -> potential clients

3.1.2.5 LinkedIn [9]

- There is a profile created for Suly Barrera but it is not used.

Suggestions:

- Creating a LinkedIn page can be a good opportunity for partnerships and sponsorship for events. It could be a way for more companies and corporate events to contact the Sulydance

[8] https://www.youtube.com/@sulydance/videos

[9] https://www.linkedin.com/company/academia-sulydance/about/

company and could finally give the festival a lot of visibility.

3.1.2.6 E-mail

- Suly just communicates by e-mail with clients and parents.

Suggestions:

- Personalise communication
- E-mails about new events, classes, schedules, shows, festivals, programmes, promotions and other news.
- "Welcome e-mail" after registration.
- "Thank you e-mail"l after selling a merch.
- Asking for feedback, surveys…
- Storytelling (personal: share a compelling story of one of your current students and how your studio has impacted them)

3.1.2.7 Whatsapp groups [10]

- One for teachers
- One for students

3.2 Current digital marketing metrics and performances

Facebook: *(on the last 90 days).*

Δ *Academia Sulydance*: (last 90 days)

- Reach: 150 053 (-20%)
- Reach of the reels: 127
- Interaction: 7377 (+4%)
- Video views on the first 3 seconds: 2382 (-92%)
- Net followers: 27 (-49%)
- New followers: 37

[10] Both used to for communication, announcements, changes, delays etc...

- Followers who unfollowed: 10
- Multimedia content based on reach: (17% followers, 83% non-followers)
- Photo: 6,9 thousand
- Multi photo 3,4 thousand
- Link: 1,8 thousand
- Others: 9,1 thousand

Δ Facebook *companhia*:

- Reach: 296 (-63%)
- Reach of the reels: 0
- Interaction: 22 (-90%)
- Video views on the first 3 seconds: 19 (-24%)
- Net followers: 3 (+50%)
- New followers: 6
- Followers who unfollowed: 3
- Multimedia content based on reach: (82,5% followers, 17,5% non-followers)
- Multimedia: 14
- Multi photo: 59
- Video: 21
- Others: 251
- Multimedia content based on interaction: (90.5% followers, 9,5% non-followers)
- Photo: 20
- Multi photo: 1

Δ Facebook *Festival*:

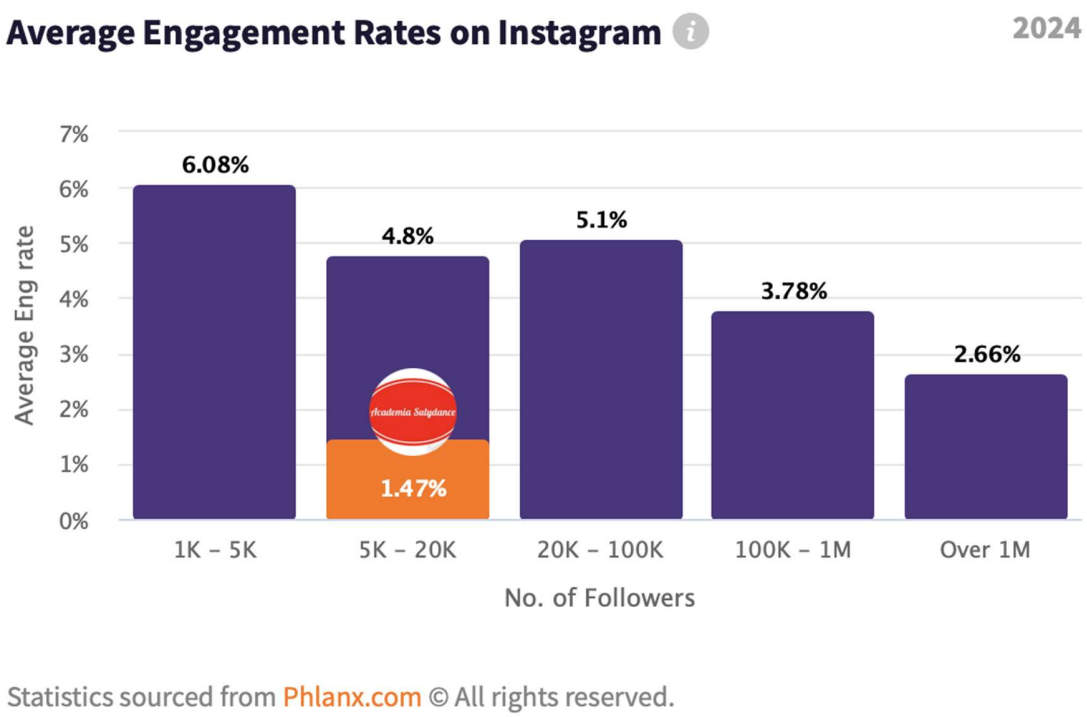
- Reach: 149 (-21%)
- Reach of the reels: 0
- Interaction: 0 (-100%)
- Video views on the first 3 seconds: 3 (-50%)
- Net followers: 1 (+200%)
- New followers: 1
- Followers who unfollowed: 0

- Multimedia content based on reach: (16% followers, 84% non-followers)
- Photo: 66
- Multi photo: 35
- Link: 35
- Others: 48

Instagram: (last 90 days)

Δ *@academia_sulydance*

- 5.3K Followers
- Engagement rate: 1.47%
- Average interactions per post: 75 likes, 8 comments



- Reach:
  - → Accounts reached: 26031
  - → Followers: 6.3%
  - → Non-followers: 93,7%
  - → Ads: 20.5%
  - → Impressions: 277k (-4,3%)

→ Type of content:

- Reels: 20.1 M
- Publications: 4495
- Stories: 1570
- Videos: 106

→ Profile activity: 6091 (-11.2%)

→ Profile visits 5953 (-10.9)

→ Main content reached: 4243 (post)

→ Interaction:

- Account interaction: 1129
- Followers: 57,.6
- Non-followers: 42,4%

→ Type of content:

→ Reels: 903

→ Posts: 831

→ Stories: 240

→ Interactions with content: 8652

→ 0,4% ads

→ Interactions with reels: 5626 (+8,5)

→ Likes: 5135

→ Comments: 283

→ Saved items: 100

→ Shares: 108

→ Interactions with posts: 2988 (+8,9)

→ Likes: 2668

→ Comments: 144

→ Saved Items: 33

- Followers: 5354 (-1,9%)

→ Growth:

→ General followers: -99

→ Followers: 207

→ Cancellations of follow-ups 306

→ Main Cities:

- Cascais - 20,6%
- Cintra: 4,2%
- Lisboa: 3,5%
- Cidade de Ho Chi Minh: 2,7%
- Oerias: 2,6%

→ Age range :

- 13-17: 4.9%
- 18-24: 18.1%
- 25-34: 16.1%
- 35-44: 25.8%
- 45-54: 24.6%
- 55-64: 8%
- 65+: 2%

→ Main Countries

- Portugal 43.7%
- Brazil 15.9%
- Vietnam 5.2%
- Indonesia 4.5%
- India 4.1%

→ Gender:

- Woman: 78,5%
- Man: 21,4%

Δ *@companhiasulydance*

- 284 Followers
- Engagement Rate: 19.22%
- Average interactions per post: 60 likes, 3 comments

Δ *@fidsdrgeral* - Festival profile

- Followers: 1.2K
- Engagement Rate: 10.40%
- Average interactions per post: 135 likes, 5 comments

- Reach:

→ Accounts reached: 749

→ Followers: 52.9%

→ Non-followers: 47.1% •

→ Impressions 2212 (-73.5%)

→ By type of content:

- Stories 374
- Reels 343
- Posts189
- Videos 6

→ Main content reach: 365 (video)

→ Profile activity 163 (-61%)

→ Profile visits 162 (-58.8%)

→ Ringtones on external calls 1 (-95.9%)

- Interaction:

- Accounts with interaction: 7
- Followers: 71.4%
- Non-followers 28.5%

→ By type of content

- Posts: 3
- Stories 3

- Reels: 1

→ Interactions with content 3 (-90)

→ Interactions with the posts 2 (-88.3%)

- Likes 2

→ Interactions with reels 1 -92.4%

- Likes 1

• Followers

- Followers 1286 (-0.4%)
- General followers -5
- Followers 25
- Cancellations of follow-ups 30

→ Cities:

- Cascais 27.9%
- Cintra 9.6%
- Lisbon 7.6%
- Oeiras 4.3%
- Amateur 3%

→ Age:

- 13-17 4.8%
- 18-24 21.8%
- 25-34 15.5%
- 35-44 24.8%
- 45-54 25.4%
- 55-64 4.5%
- 65+ 2.9%

→ Countries

- Portugal 93.4%
- USA 2.6%
- Brazil 0.7%
- Spain 0.5%
- Cuba 0.3%

→ Gender

- Women: 82,4%
- Men: 17,5%

Tik-Tok: (60 days)

- Post Views 44K (+43K (+6766.8%)
- Profile Views 901 (+866 (+2474.3%)
- Comments 66 (+66)
- Likes 1,932 (+1,895 (+5121.6%)
- Shares 18 (+18)
- Individual viewers 31K (+31K (+33728.7%)
- Total followers 375

→ Net Followers 110 (+41.51%)

→ Follower Insights Gender

- Masculine 27%
- Feminine 73%

→ Age:

- 18-24 42.2%
- 25-34 19.5%
- 35-44 20.6%
- 45-54 12.8%
- 55+ 5.0%

→ Most active times Hours Days In the last 7 days, most of your followers were active on May 20th at 7pm. (91 followers)

→ Countries/Regions with the most followers

- Portugal 91.1%
- Brazil 2.0%
- Spain 1.7%
- Philippines 1.1%
- 0.8% Mexico

- 0.6% United Arab Emirates
- 0.6% Argentina
- 0.6% Switzerland
- 0.6% Mozambique

4. Goals of our digital marketing strategy

4.1 Short-term goals (1-3 years)

Here are the 3 main goals of our imminent and next future strategy:

- **Enhance the value proposition of the company**
- **Increase the brand awareness, especially in Amadora**
- **Increase customers**

We have defined these strategic objectives for Sulydance to ensure the company's short-term success. By strengthening our value proposition, we offer customers more compelling reasons to choose Sulydance, this may include unique courses, high-quality teachers or a stimulating learning atmosphere. However, at the same time, by increasing brand awareness, particularly the new opening location in Amadora this year, we are ensuring that more potential customers are aware of Sulydance and its offerings. Finally, by increasing the number of students, we are broadening our customer base and ensuring the viability of the business. In short, these strategic objectives work together to position Sulydance as a leader in the dance industry in Amadora and beyond.

4.2 Long-term goals (5 years)

Here are the goals of the strategy in the long run:

- **Additional schools across the country**
- **Expanding the range of dance styles offered**
- **Organizing bigger events**
- **Participate in European and international dance competitions**

Suly, the founder of Sulydance, also shares ambitious long-term strategic goals that build on this solid foundation: although she will just open a new location in Amadora shortly, she aims to open additional schools across the country. Then she wants to expand the styles of dance offered, to attract a wider audience, and we suggest running awareness campaigns to publicize these new styles. Organizing bigger events will increase student involvement and generate additional income from sponsors. For instance, McDonald's is currently a sponsor, but other sponsors are featured on the website, suggesting potential for further development. Finally, participation in prestigious dance competitions, such as the European competition in Tarragona and, in the future, the international competition in Orlando, is a dream that Suly hopes will come true. Financially, taking part in these competitions is a challenge for the school, but a sound financial strategy will make it

possible.

By combining our initial strategic goals with Suly's ambitious visions, we can propel Sulydance into a lasting bright future.

5. Digital marketing tactics

Aligning the goals of our Strategy, and to elevate Sulydance Academy's online presence and transform the customer experience, we propose the following digital marketing tactics that will be applied - and improved - both in the short and long-term across the next 5 years:

- **SEO:** Sulydance's website currently lacks search engine visibility. Optimizing the website with these keywords throughout headings, subheadings, blog posts, and website text will significantly improve search ranking.
- **Targeted ads on search and social media**: We will utilize relevant keywords such as "*Escola de dança para crianças*"[11], "*Estúdio de dança Cascais*"[12] or "*Estúdio de dança Lisboa*" to be in front of the right audience and ensure that our ads reach new potential students.
- **Google My Business:** Claiming a Google My Business profile ensures Sulydance appears on Google Maps when people search for dance studios nearby. This increases local discoverability.
- **Online Registration:** Offering online registration streamlines the enrollment process, improving convenience for potential customers.
- **Content Marketing:** Engaging content tailored for platforms like TikTok, Instagram, and Facebook will attract new audiences. Consider live-streaming classes on these platforms. Parents watching their children's progress can foster a sense of pride and satisfaction, potentially leading to enrollment.
- **Loyalty Programs:** A loyalty program for returning students (rebookings) can incentivize continued enrollment with merchandise gadgets, discounts on tuition fees and discounts with partners (e.g McDonald's Cascais, which Sulydance Academy already have as a sponsor)
- **Referral programs:** Offering rewards for bringing new students with the initiative "*trazer um amigo*".[13] Offering a tuition discount for customers who bring in new students will help to get more new students into the classes.

- **E-mail Marketing:** Targeted email marketing allows promoting exclusive merchandise and special offers directly to existing customers.

[11] "Dance studios for kids" in English
[12] "Cascais dance studios" in English
[13] "Bring a friend" in English

- **Webshop:** create a part on the website for selling Sulydance Academy merchandise. Students already buy the t-shirts of the dance school but it would be a good idea to create a digital shop with other gadgets too.

- **Sulydance Academy App:** Developing a mobile app would be a significant differentiator. Imagine an app where users can book classes, provide feedback, and even acknowledge teachers' contributions. Push notifications can deliver event reminders, updates, and class registration prompts. Sharing student videos and photos through the app fosters a sense of community and can motivate potential students to enroll.

- **VR/AR Integration (Future):** While not an immediate focus, Virtual Reality and Augmented Reality could be explored in the next 5 years. Offering online immersive dance classes and interactive experience in which students will choose if coming to class or attending from another place, ideally their living room at home.

6. Metrics to measure and optimize

According to our strategy's goals, these are the following metrics we are going to measure and optimize along the next few years.

- **Website traffic**

  By tracking the number of visitors, Sulydance can assess the attractiveness of its site and identify which pages or content attract the most interest. In addition, this metric helps to understand visitor behaviour, which can guide improvements to the user experience and site optimisation.

  Traffic growth rate (%) = [(Current month's traffic - Previous month's traffic) / Previous month's traffic] X 100

- **Social Media Engagement Rate**

  Social media engagement measures how much your audience interacts with your social media posts in the form of the number of likes, comments, and shares.

  Social Media Engagement Rate % = (Like + Comments + Share) / Followers

  By applying these steps, Suly Dance Academia will be able to effectively measure and optimize its engagement on social networks

- **Student Retention and Student Churn rate**

  The **Student Retention Rate** calculates the percentage of students who continue staying in the school after one year/semester.

  This is the ratio of the number of retained customers to the number at risk.

  Retention Rate = ((Number of students at the end of the period - New students acquired during the period) / Number of students at the beginning of the period) X 100

  The **Student Churn Rate** is the percentage of students who stop being customers of the dance school and stop dancing or they change schools.

  Churn Rate = (Total students lost over the period / Total subscribers at the start of the period) X 100

  By using the Retention Rate and Churn Rate, Sulydance Academy could:

1. Enrolment tracking system: Use student management software to track enrolments and de-enrolments.
2. Regular analysis: Perform these calculations at the end of each defined period to identify trends and act accordingly.

3. Improvement actions: Use the results to implement actions to improve retention, such as loyalty programmes, regular feedback, and improvements based on student feedback.

- **Students Attendance rate**

  The **Student's Attendance Rate** measures how much the students will attend class.

  A low attendance rate may indicate problems such as inappropriate lessons, inconvenient timetables or teaching difficulties. This allows the school to take corrective action.

  Attendance Rate = (Number of Attendees / (Number of Attendees + Number of Absences)) X 100

  By using the Attendance Rate Sulydance Academy could:

1. Collect attendance data: Record student attendance for each lesson. Use a digital system or an attendance sheet.
2. Analyse the results: Compare retention rates between different periods and groups to identify trends.
3. Take action: If the retention rate is low, explore ways to improve student engagement, such as diversifying courses, offering incentives, or collecting feedback to improve the experience.

- **CTR (click-through rate)**

  The **Click-Through Rate** would measure the effectiveness of an advertising, email, or link. It essentially represents the percentage of customers (students or parents) who would see the advertising or email and then click on it.

  CTR = (Clicks / Impressions) x 100

  A high CTR generally indicates that the advertising or email is successful in capturing user attention and prompting them to take action.

- **App engagement rate**

  The app engagement rate for Sulydance school refers to the percentage of students who actively interact with the app on a regular basis. It's a metric that helps to understand how well the app is retaining users and understanding how many times they used and for how much time.

  *Engagement Rate (%) = (MAU) / Total Users * 100*

- *MAU (Monthly Active Users): The number of unique users who open the app within a month.*
- *Total Users: The total number of users who have downloaded your app.*

- **Net Promoter Score (NPS)**

  The NPS is used to identify and analyze the level of satisfaction among consumers of a product and/or customers of a brand.

  NPS = % of promoters - % of detractors

  To improve customer experience, Sulydance Academy will collect Net Promoter Score (NPS) through surveys and emails. Promoters will be encouraged for referrals and reviews, while passives may receive incentives for further engagement. Detractors' feedback will be analyzed to address their concerns. The NPS question asks for recommendation likelihood (0-10) with a reason, and surveys will be sent after enrollment, term ends, special events, via email, text message, or physical forms. Online tools will be used for collection.

6.1 Benchmark marketing metrics

Despite finding some metrics of the dance school industry in 2024, we realized that they were not relevant with our case and our goals. Thus, based on a combination of sources and industry knowledge, we found through AI search engines the industry averages of the following metrics of the market, coming from marketing blogs and social media management platform:

- **Website traffic**: 1,000 - 5,000 monthly visitors (can be higher for established schools)
- **Social Media Engagement Rate**: 1% - 5% (percentage of followers who like/comment/share your posts)
- **Student Retention Rate**: 60% - 80% (percentage of students who stay enrolled after the first term)
- **Student Churn rate**: between 15-20% as a low rate, between 25 to 35% as a high churn rate.
- **Attendance rate**: between 60 to 75 % the average.
- **CTR**: The average CTR for email marketing campaigns in the dance school industry is between 2 to 5%.
- **App engagement rate**: *Localytics* analysis found that dance school apps have an average engagement rate of 35 per cent, with users opening the app an average of 2 times per week.
- **NPS**: For dance schools, an NPS of 20 to 50 could be considered a good range. Below 20 would indicate a need for improvement, cause students might be dissatisfied with instruction,

communication, or facilities. Between 20-50 is suggesting that some students are promoters (likely to recommend the school) while others are passives (satisfied but not enthusiastic), while above 50 would signify a high likelihood of student recommendations and positive word-of-mouth.

7. Marketing plan

In the past Suly already spent money on marketing activities, and even if she never measured it, according to what she says, investments on the website, paid media and events have always brought back in return more students enrolled over the years. Namely, we know she outsourced the activities to a marketer freelancer by spending 650 € for the creation of the website, plus 15 € per month for multiple changes during the year, every year; 50 € every time for producing posters in various formats; social media advertising for sponsoring posts between 20-40 € a month.

Aligning with our short and long-term goals, here below we suggest a marketing plan that Suly could implement step by step, to invest more in marketing activities but obtain better results that could eventually contribute to generating value for her business. Besides the budget estimates and the activities proposed this plan is programmed to achieve the KPIs set for the next years, and we want to underline the importance we gave to the NPS metric, which according to the values of the company would represent how much Suly and the other employees care about the customer experience of the students.

7.1 First year

Although we would like the school to start making the following suggestions, we want to keep it real for the first year, thus we suggest filling in the parts where the company lacks. Indeed, within the first year, starting as soon as possible, there are a lot of things that could be immediately improved with most of them having ZERO costs - or at least with a low budget -, but of course, we need to be patient and forget to expect having great results or pretending to reach great results in KPI's.

Budget:

The cost of paying per performance of a social media and SEO freelancer for a year varies based on many factors, considering Suly already has one that is paid 15 € a month, by increasing the activities the service could be about 30-50 euros per month, roughly **between 360 to 600 € in a year.**

KPI's to achieve:

- Increase of social media engagement rate (+ 51 %)[14]
- Increase the website traffic (+ 49 to 71 %)[15]
- Having a positive NPS (at least 20 %)

Activities:

- SEO
- Website available in English and Spanish language beside portuguese
- Claiming a Google My business profile in order to appear on google maps
- Applicate all the suggestions and guidelines made about website and social media (see paragraph 3.2)
- Start keeping track of social media interaction and measure social media engagement
- Surveys (for feedbacks and to start measuring NPS)

7.2 Year 3

Within 3 years, according Suly's vision, thus the next opening of the school in Amadora, the expansion of the range of dance styles offered, the organization of bigger dance events and the first participation in - at least in this moment - european dance competitions, we planned the following activities that will require a more expensive budget but would bring many benefits to the company.

Budget:

We suggest hiring a marketing intern dedicated only to digital marketing who could give most of his time to handle the marketing activities suggested, but we also suggest pairing him up with the job performance of a digital marketing specialist. Thus, the intern could cost roughly 500 € per

[14] According to an analysis of Sprout Social companies that use social media are 51 percent more likely to increase engagement rates than those that do not.
[15] A *BrightLocal* survey found that businesses with a Google My Business tab are 71% more likely to get local customers than those without one; A *Hootsuite* study found that businesses that use social media are 49% more likely to increase web traffic than those that do not; and A *Moz* analysis found that companies with a strong SEO strategy are 53% more likely to get organic customers than those with a weak SEO strategy.

month, and a Digital Marketing Specialist 16 euros[16] on average for an hour, supposing only a once-a-month support with the intern. The budget will be roughly 7.000 € a year just for the personnel. Furthermore, the company should need money for sponsoring social media advertising: if we consider the [17]average cost x click and the expected reach on Instagram, Facebook and TikTok, around 50 euros x month, 600 € annually. In total around **7.600 € x year.**

KPI's to achieve:

- Increase social media engagement rates (+100%)
- Increase website traffic (+100%)
- Positive NPS (40%)
- Attendance rate (80%)
- Retention rate (75%)
- Churn rate (25%)

Activities:

- Measurement of social media engagement periodically to understand which platforms to use with the proper contents
- Measurement of attendance, retention and churn rate (using an online database)
- All the email suggestions provided in paragraph 3.1.2.7 (communicate schedules, shows, announcements, storytelling stories) since in the next years with the opening of a new school will have more audience to reach
- Ongoing paid social media ads for the first 12 months from the opening of Amadora and other non-recurring occasions, events and national competitions on first place
- Content marketing is on the right platforms where your customers are (both students and parents), so hypothetically still Instagram, TikTok, and Facebook are the main ones. All taking into account the suggestions made for social media (see paragraph 3.2).

[16] https://www.salaryexpert.com/salary/job/digital-marketing-specialist/portugal#:~:text=33%20662%20%E2%82%AC%20(EUR)%2Fyr&text=An%20entry%20level%20digital%20marketing,salary%20of%2041%20336%20%E2%82%AC.

[17] https://www.adroll.com/blog/ad-cost-breakdown-facebook-instagram-tiktok-and-pinterest

7.3 Year 5

Following the greatest ambitions of the company, Sulydance Academy is supposed to have multiple schools across the country by the next 5 years, not 15 or 10, but why not from 4 to 7, who knows… But for sure we know that to support this vision Suly has to take into consideration considerably raise at this point the budget for marketing activities, which maybe nowadays is not crucial, but for sure it will be with the growth of the number of students, online audience, events and participation to continental and international dance competitions.

Budget:

In the long run with the expected opening of new schools, it's required doing some adjustments following the past yearly budgets in marketing. Thus, that's why we suggest hiring a digital marketing specialist full-time that could handle all the activities - an entry-level cost of around 24.000 x year in Portugal -, sustain miscellaneous costs for general marketing activities, software and tools (2.000 €) and the budget spent for the app of Sulydance academy between 5.000 and 10.000 € at first plus some other costs of app maintenance (500 euros x month). Everything for a total budget of **35.000/40.000 euros**, decreased by 10k in the following years.

For the VR/AR idea we don't want to make accurate calculations cause the market is still not well developed but although it is not on this budget we think could be applied as well with the costs that follow.

KPI's to achieve:

- User acquisition and engagement metrics on the app - like app downloads, active users ecc… - around 35 %[18].
- Sales through the website[19]
- CTR - click through rate of e-mails, to know how many people open the email and click on the links inside it. Between 2-5%.[20]
- Increase exponentially the NPS (60% compared to 40% of the past years)

[18] A Localytics analysis found that dance school apps have an average engagement rate of 35 percent, with users opening the app an average of 2 times per week.

[19] Exact number depends on too many factors

[20] The average CTR for email marketing campaigns in the dance school industry is around 2-5%.

Activities:

- Loyalty programs
- Referral programs
- Webshop, that will eventually increase the sales in merchandise
- E-mail Marketing, so targeted email marketing promoting merchandise and special offers directly to existing customers.
- Sulydance academy app
- VR and AR integration

8. Conclusions and lessons learned

Having come to the end of this project, we can conclude that it has been extremely educational though very challenging, the positive aspects have been many.
Humanely we found out from behind the scenes how the entrepreneurial aspect behind running a dance school does it work, something that none of us knew.

Also, we had the opportunity to apply the concepts and the metrics learned in class in a real business case.
In fact, in the course of the project and in writing this report, we simulated a well-detailed marketing plan so that it can be truly applied.
Our goal ever since we met Suly has been to try to help her, to offer her a free service in exchange for information and her valuable time.
We think that this report can be of great value to her and that our plan will be implemented according to our guidelines, hoping to support the ambitious goals of the company and to enhance the customer experience with our ideas.
In conclusion, we hope that our work will generate a positive impact on this small business.

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Annex Suly'Interview

Daniela: What is the mission of the school?

Suly: At this moment, I have the sixth student who is going to enter the higher dance course. There are two higher education schools to study dance. You have the higher school of dance and the faculty of human motricity.

Daniela: Is the first one like the conservatory?

Suly: No, the conservatory is something else. The conservatory prepares you to be a dancer and go directly to professional companies. As for the faculty of human motricity and the higher school of dance, the higher school is very oriented towards dancers and the faculty towards teachers. But I have several teachers from here from the higher school. At this moment, I have 3 girls in the higher school, 2 in the faculty, one of whom just graduated recently and one who just entered the faculty as well. Every year, someone from here enters higher dance courses.

Daniela: Great, that's good. Up to what age do you have students now?

Suly: It's open. I don't have adults. This lady because she had experience. Only because of that, did I let her attend the classes. She attends ballet and sevillanas classes.

Daniela: Okay, so from 3 years old up to?

Suly: From 3 until it's open-ended. What happens is that an adult won't come here having been trained somewhere else and then start taking my classes. That doesn't happen. I end up having adults now, but they started here as children. The adults that are here are because they were trained here. For example, Raquel is 22 years old. Raquel was trained here.

Daniela: So, for example, an adult can only join if they have prior training...

Suly: If they have training, we let them try a class to see if they adapt. Also, because I can't take the whole group and start everything over. This is vocational, there is supposed to be a continuity of work. You understand? The lady is not going to study dance anymore. She's here just to learn. What happens is that she adapts well, she doesn't disturb, she doesn't interfere, and she learns at the same speed as the children, otherwise, she wouldn't be here. Because there is continuity. Our interest is for them to either go to university to study something else, but while they are here they have many activities, shows, events, training, preparation, top group classes, sevillanas classes, ballet classes, they have everything. For example, those who excel in sevillanas are the ones who do ballet. It's noticeable. Those who don't do ballet, maybe do contemporary, and their bodies might look a bit different. They need to be guided differently. This group wasn't mine. It was Leonor's. I took it over 2 months ago. So, I had to create that choreography in a month and a half for the show. Because they were working on something else, and I, out of work ethics, don't use what was being done before. If you left and went away, well, I have to do it again.

Daniela: Okay, and then, does a student have to take a minimum number of styles or can they just take one style?

Suly: No, the academy's policy is not to force anyone to do anything but to encourage them.

Daniela: Got it.

Suly: Okay, I can tell you: you have to do... you have to realize it yourself, you know? That's why we have performances; the performances we choose are also about analyzing that, so one sees the others... and they might get interested because my own student is a strong potential client for another style. I am interested in people from outside, but my own student is a huge potential, because first, if they enroll in more styles, the training is much better. It's not just about finances; it has to do with the vigor, with maintaining the academy's image, you know? The kids are versatile; they leave here dancing various styles, and I am interested in maintaining that, and only in that way.

Daniela: Do you have the class prices online?

Suly: Everything is online on the website. On the website, you have the price list, schedules, and there's also a table, because people used to call me a lot asking, well, and Latin 1 is what age? Latin 2 is what age? So, a table was made and put on the site to inform interested people. I never received calls again. This is the most visited page on the site.

Daniela: You can see all that.

Suly: These are last year's schedules; you can see that this year's image is identical.

Matteo: Is it also on Instagram?

Suly: Yes, yes. Sometimes I pin the posts. Right now, I'm not interested in having it there. It's not important because soon, in 15 days, something else will come out. It's confusing. Right now, it's not interesting because this already works; what interests me is that the new ones don't get confused.

Daniela: Are you going to keep the same prices?

Suly: Everything the same. In fact, the same prices here, the same prices in Amadora. Because I don't want anyone to feel like, "Oh, because we live in Cascais, we pay more." We balance things out; it seemed to us that the prices were fair. So, whoever takes one class per week pays 30 euros, two classes per week pays 48 euros, three classes pay 65 euros, four classes 81 euros, and five times per week 100 euros. Those who take topgroup...

Daniela: What is topgroup?

Suly: Topgroup is a selection. For example, there are kids who can practice twice a week, and it could be ballet and contemporary, or ballet and sevillanas. What happens is you have kids who never meet but are excellent. So, this topgroup is the group, and we as teachers are scouts; we have to watch who is standing out and bring them together in one place. That's the topgroup. The

topgroup is like a rotation of teachers, meaning the student stays the same, and the teacher rotates. They have hip hop, they have Latin, they have sevillanas. They have everything. They get training from everyone because, in the end, that's what we want. The final product is a versatile child who can do everything. So, they work for a trimester, for example, until the performance, they worked on hip hop. There are two: the top group junior B, grouped by ages, and the top group junior A, which are more advanced levels. It's an extra. They pay for it separately, but they also have access to, it's like everyone would like to have, you know, paying for just one class. But to get there, you have to have gone through a lot. It's like the opposite, you know? You might even be invited if you do two styles, but then you get there and start realizing it, so you go directly for it. I don't force anyone to do anything here. Not even to buy a T-shirt, and you've seen that most have one. No one is forced to buy anything. They just have to come dressed in black, nothing else. What happens is that if I see my friend, I also want it. I don't have to force you; you will want it...

Matteo: You said you have like 164 students, but is that for a semester, for a year?

Suly: For a year.

Matteo: So, it starts in September?

Suly: From September to July.

Matteo: So, in August, closed?

Suly: We open registrations now on May 20. Normally, I do it in May. Once the show ends in April, I start preparing. As you've seen, I have everything ready, the registrations for September. The child doesn't leave here without being registered. What do I do? I offer a discount as an incentive. And I secure them for the next year.

Matteo: People that don't want to continue anymore have to leave in May?

Suly: No, no, only in July.

Daniela: Because they pay every month, but at the beginning, do they pay a registration fee?

Suly: They pay an annual registration fee. That's what they will pay in May to secure their spot for the next year. Normally, it's 40 euros per year, including insurance, and 30 if you do it during pre-registration. We usually open it in May (May 20) and it goes until the last day of July when we are open. If you haven't done it by then, in September, when you come, it's 40 euros.

Daniela: Do you know who your competitors are?

Suly: I don't have any. There are other dance schools, but for example, there's Edam, which is classical and modern. There's a place that just started in Aboboda offering contemporary, classical, and character dances (Russian dances). Then there's Primeiro de Maio where Xana is now, ballet, and I think they have some hip-hop classes, but honestly, I don't see much expression there; ballet, yes, but not hip-hop. Then there's Jazzy, which opened recently in the area. The

thing with Jazzy is that it's a very commercial school where students don't have continuity, so it's very different from mine. My objective is exactly the opposite, so it's not direct competition.

Matteo: That's your differentiation.

Suly: Completely, the continuous training. The only school I would say, oh, there's Levarte in Murtal (ballet and Irish dances).

Matteo: Are the students from here?

Suly: Yes, and from Sintra too. Cascais, Estoril. Most are from São Domingos de Rana. That's why I'm taking a risk in another place as well.

Daniela: And why Amadora?

Suly: Because it came up and first because of the population density. Amadora is the second city with the highest population density in Portugal. First because of the advantages I'll have in the place. They were the ones who showed interest. I contacted them to perform Bernarda. The House of Bernarda Alba. He told me, you have to come meet with me because it's not just Bernarda, you should set up a school here. We had a meeting, he showed me the building, it has 5 floors. He asked me where I wanted, and I liked the top floor. So they are going to do the renovations from scratch, and then we'll go all out with my branding. The architect is doing the 3D, and she asked me what I wanted. We are going to use the same visual identity. The colors…

We've always maintained the visual identity. Even in shows, although the theme is different, it's clear that it's us behind the event. So this is the new location, which will have everything the same as here. (She shows a video of the space and the concept she wants for the space). Only then can it be a platform for many bookings.
Daniela: Other than that, what do you want for this school this year? Do you want to achieve something? Something specific?
Suly: Normally, every year we have a work plan here. Every year, the objectives are met. This year, I didn't go to any international festival, but I always aim to take the kids to those kinds of events because it gives them the experience and the push to know what it's like to be in a group, to work in a team, and to fight as a team. That's what I want to focus on this year. I want to take them to an international hip-hop event. Usually, we go to competitions that include all the modalities. It's very rare for me to take my kids to a competition that is just one style. I'm not interested in taking them to a flamenco festival because my school is not just about flamenco. So much so that the company's image will change because it's too focused on flamenco.
Daniela: But with the company, you are currently only doing flamenco, right?
Suly: Unfortunately. That's going to change. I'm going to change the image because I have a school that teaches everything, and the company is only doing flamenco. I'm limiting myself when I have people who are trained in various styles. I can do more, something that appeals to more people, more commercial.
Daniela: So with the company, you want to expand the styles.
Suly: That's definitely going to happen this year. The company's shows are already more professional. The company sells shows, does events outside, and is contracted for many things, but only in flamenco. Now, I want the shows to obviously include flamenco, but I want to add a theme...

Daniela: How do you select people for the company?
Suly: Initially, it was the student who continued with dance who was invited directly. Now, no. Now, I start observing the effort, dedication, and desire. Wanting to go to university doesn't necessarily mean that they are completely ready in my view.

Daniela: And from what age can they join?
Suly: They can join from 15/16 years old, when they can work and get paid. Almost all of them are already issuing receipts. Everything is done formally as it should be.
Daniela: The school is looking to participate in more diversified festivals...
Suly: We usually go to the ones we organize ourselves. We do the selection and take them to festivals. To the All Dance, which is the biggest festival in the world, and it has several stages. The All Dance has the national stage (Porto), and the 23 awards here are from All Dance, all national. From these 23 awards, I had 21 qualified for the European stage. I could have gone to Tarragona where the All Dance Europe was held. From this festival, I had 17/18 choreographies qualified for the world stage. And then you decide if you want to go to the European stage or the world stage, which is in Orlando. I wanted to go, but it's expensive, costly, the tickets... because qualifying means you have quality, but the financial part is up to you.
Matteo: How do you use social media? Because I saw that you post on Instagram and Facebook, but you stopped on TikTok.
Daniela: She is posting on TikTok.
Suly: Yes.
Matteo: Recently?
Suly: Yes. I started posting on TikTok very recently. Very, very recently. I have to adapt to TikTok because it was a platform I had very little faith in, but now I'm starting to see it has a very good, very large reach.

Matteo: Do you have the average?

Suly: The average would be around 6 years, but that's being conservative. Very conservative.

Daniela: And for the teachers?

Suly: The average is about 4 years. Almost. I had Xana for 8 years, Diandra for 6, Leonor for 5, and the others started more recently. I've had Helena since 2019, which is 5 years. Considering the school has been around for 15 years, I've had many. David joined right after Diandra left, in 2020. So, 4 years as well.

Daniela: Are you the one handling all the marketing?

Suly: For now, yes, but I have a meeting next week with a company.

This is a small business, a micro-enterprise. And large dance companies, like the Royal or those in London, are subsidized by the state, which is a different level altogether. For instance, here with DGest. I'm going to present my project to DGest between February and April next year.

Daniela: Do you know what DGest is? (to Matteo)

Suly: It's the Directorate-General for the Arts here in Portugal. It’s the regulatory body that supports the arts.

Daniela: It's not just about the arts, but also, for example, when you want to see what you want to study for university, you can go to DGest, and they have all the information about everything.

Matteo: Can you go physically?

Daniela: You have the website, you can call, have interviews for guidance.

Daniela: So you’re going to apply?

Suly: Because of the company. The academy already has a lot of support from the Cascais council.

Daniela: And you want to have that with the company?

Suly: Yes, because the company needs to have a structure like the academy has. That’s another challenge because it’s more difficult for a company to sustain itself. To be self-sufficient. Right now, the dancers are with me because they want to be, but they can’t come to rehearse without getting paid. While they are not yet professionals, they haven’t finished graduating either. So, we are doing semi-professional work.

Daniela: Because in a professional company, they are always getting paid?

Suly: No. There’s a contract, and they earn a salary. Whether you have rehearsals today or the day after tomorrow, it works with a contract. For example, a dancer should have ballet classes, contemporary classes, and the company’s style class once a day. One class of each. Then you have the performances. Saturdays, Friday nights, Sundays... and the dancer gets paid monthly, and the company contracts with other entities. But the company should have a PR person, a structure that I don’t have... yet. I can only achieve that with government support. Companies in Portugal that operate well do so because they have government support. I do it because I’m passionate. It’s my strong desire.

Daniela: So the logo you want is SulyDance.

Suly: I just registered it on the 22nd. Since I'm expanding to Amadora, I registered the brand at a national level for now. On April 22nd.

Daniela: And the other one, which is just ASD?

Suly: No, it will remain as a complementary brand.

Daniela: The icon?

Suly: Yes. I don't intend to patent it.

Daniela: You're now focusing more on personal branding, right? How do you want to relate that, and what is your objective with it?

Suly: My goal is to have several schools all over the country. The brand image, like the image of Nespresso, is theirs. The image of the school has to be me. For the school, for the house, for another school... the common thread has to be my image and my thinking. The way I see things. I'll have to make partnerships, and it will have to be written down what cannot fail. The part about personal relationships, the part about how the students feel, the part where the teacher gives a hug and a kiss to each child... that part cannot fail anywhere. My image is currently in process. I hadn't realized to what extent my persona had become the academy. I am no longer Suly. I am the academy. I stopped being a person to become the business. And that's very bad. It could be the opposite; I have many things that can benefit the academy as a personal brand. I want to do many things. I can create courses to sell online, for people who are at home and cannot get up from their chairs to also do it at home, even if it's just with their arms... there's an online aspect of me...

Daniela: Those products you mentioned, the courses...

Suly: I already have an e-book I made that's selling, little by little. I created an e-book called "Practical Guide for Parents of Dancers". I don't advertise it. Because right now, that's not important. What's more important is the multitude of projects I have. It's like a guide, because parents come, and if the place looks nice, they enroll their child. And I have competition from people who haven't even studied. That's serious because the child has a joint problem, and you don't even know the name of the joint. How are you going to teach children if you haven't even had training? I teach them how to do a bun, how to do makeup... ideally, I would do that on a small scale and be able to give it out.

Sure, here's the translation of the interview from Spanish to English:

Daniela: Do you have a professional profile on Instagram?

Suly: No.

Daniela: That was important to be able to see the statistics.

Suly: Do you think it's important?

Daniela: Yes, because if you want to relate your academy with your personal brand... we will also indicate that later.

Daniela: Then you wouldn't be able to get the statistics.

Suly: I can give you whatever you want. I post every day. I have a lot of content, including things yet to be published.

Matteo: It would be interesting to see the difference between the metrics between months. Can we have access to his profile (academy)?

Suly: Yes, yes... both... I realize that when I talk it rises, it shoots up...

Matteo: If we could have access to every social media. Facebook, Instagram, and TikTok, because they're all important. Facebook for the parents, TikTok for students...

Suly: That's what happens, my client is the student, but who pays is the parent.

Daniela: How do you communicate with the parents?

Suly: By email. Or when they come here. Bruno talks a lot with the parents.

Daniela: Do they have any type of meeting?

Suly: I hold an annual, initial meeting that they don't attend. I don't know if it's good or bad, it seems to me that they're too...

Daniela: Do they have any way to express if they're happy or not?

Suly: By email. If anyone has a problem, they come here.

Daniela: And with the teachers, how do you communicate with them?

Suly: I see the teachers daily and we talk, but it's just runners. We also have a WhatsApp group and for example, today...

Matteo: You have a WhatsApp group for the students?

Suly: Yes. Each group has one, only the students...

Daniela: So they communicate via WhatsApp, do they have regular meetings? (teachers)

Suly: Now it's time to have one for the group passes, and I also want to have an individual one. I usually have a group one, but I also want an individual one. Most of my teachers are former students who became teachers. For example, the one who left here, Leonor, is not even a teacher because she hasn't even graduated, she was here as a monitor teacher. They even earn differently.

Daniela: What are your challenges? What would you say are your difficulties as a company?

Suly: Honestly, I believe it comes down to the teachers. The sudden departures, it's very strange. Just that, which is quite a lot. They always leave before big events, almost as if tempting things to go wrong. I think, to a certain extent, those who have left have become competition, so that's the problem.

Daniela: Do you have any cases of someone who left in a good way and is now competition?

Suly: No. That's why I say I think the problem starts with them. They see how it is, they think they've learned and they'll reproduce it elsewhere. Leonor is going to teach classes just two blocks away from here. With another person, who was the only teacher I had to dismiss from

here. She entered when she was pregnant. She was here for about a year. When I returned, the girls started to miss her. Because she was one of those people who said, "Well, because with me it's like this, here they don't let me, if it were me..." I accepted her here, but she already had a school in Oeiras, in Caxias. A school with 10 students. And Raquel the other day was talking to me, explaining that at the time they didn't realize it, but Patricia had a lot of influence on Leonor. Because she's a very free teacher who doesn't need anyone... it's like she seduces. And Raquel was telling me that Raquel started telling her that she would love to go dancing at night with her, and she identified a lot with her because she started telling her that she didn't need to belong to a company or a dance group to shine. That's why I say, if all the teachers who have left here, have turned into competition in a negative way. This teacher who just left here is a veteran and she's one of the teachers I admire the most in the dance world. Her name is Noelia Ferraz. She was a professional dancer in Brazil, she has an enormous CV. Why is she here? She's not a teacher at my school, she's here because she's invited for 2 months to teach a restricted group from CID. CID is a group that I created, it's an intensive dance course. It's a group that prepares for exams, the exams start now for university. I partnered with the chamber, the chamber pays, the student doesn't pay anything, and they prepare intensively for 2 months before their university exam. If you are someone who promotes the creation of new professionals, do you think I have problems? I could also say goodbye at 18 and have my life sorted out. I wouldn't have these competition problems, that thing of opening a school two blocks away is in each one's ethics.

Matteo: Two questions. You said before that you don't have direct competitors here. Have you noticed over the past years other things distracting the students, like other sports instead of coming to dance?

Suly: They only do dance. This becomes their life. And I know it's a lot because I've started to go through it, for my own sake, for my image. What Leonor's parents asked for, they own a restaurant, was business management, this was a struggle for her to be able to study dance. The parents didn't want it. For example, she practiced skating, at a certain point she stopped because I proposed it to her, because I told her, you're not going to be a good skater and a good dancer. You have to choose one or the other. I'm sure all those girls bring that thing of wanting to be like her. They visualize themselves a little in the future with me. They grow up and change, I'm the same one who taught them since they were little, and then they also have influences from outside. I've been seriously considering with Bruno, if at 18... because I'm not going to be creating my own competition either. I have to see how far, because imagine that all the girls who have trained like her here do the same to me. It's about ethics, but I can't discuss ethics with you. Either I take measures, they sign a contract that there's confidentiality, that part of the ethics of unfair competition, because that's unfair competition. I think a contract would solve it.

Daniela: Who manages the website?

Suly: There's a girl who handles that, and there's a company, I also oversee that. I pay for the hosting every month. I have the password.

Daniela: Can you make changes to it?

Suly: Yes, the girl does.

Daniela: And do you have access to view the website statistics?

Suly: Yes, I have access to everything.

Daniela: So, do you have partnerships with the Chamber of Cascais?

Suly: I have many partners. For each event, I have different partners. I have yearly partnerships. I have McDonald's (they pay for visibility). Photography partnerships. For shows, I don't have the Chamber, the Chamber is more for these social types of things. The festival, the project of preparing children for university...

Matteo: Do you have any that you don't have and would like?

Suly: No, no.

Daniela: Why is it more in their interest than yours?

Suly: It's mutual because they get visibility and help me financially. And I already got the best partnership for this world, which is So Dança. The biggest dance store in the world. In the festival, they come and set up a stand to sell things. So Dança works with levels, national, European, and world. My festival aims for the national, meaning I give prizes to go directly to the national All Dance. There are partnerships here that are not just financial; they have a sense of interest in dance.

Daniela: And about the prizes, are they for the winners or...?

Suly: You have the festival, it evolves, I started with 200 attendees. The seventh festival had 866. Schools, I started with 15/16 participating schools, this year there were 46 schools.

Daniela: And do you have a website for the festival?

Suly: It's included in a tab within my website, that was also strategic because it interests me. I don't want the festival to be dissociated from the academy. When they enter the site, they see that this group has the festival. I have it in Spanish, English, and Portuguese because the festival has a more international projection. The academy is national.

Matteo: It makes sense to have partnerships with schools, for example, where I live in a residence, they offer car services there, they say you have a 50% discount if you want.

Daniela: The thing is her mission, she wants to prepare dancers.

Matteo: And the school for children, maybe?

Daniela: Do you have any partnerships with the educational system?

Suly: Not yet. And I don't want to. And I'll explain why. After studying, I realized that. Because that's called EAE (Specialized Artistic Education), a protocol is made with a primary school and the student stops having, for example, physical education to have dance. It's also a vocational school. The only difference is that it's graded. What happens? It's that the program is very closed.

We're talking about having ballet and modern programs. If the girl is 11 years old, she has to start pointe shoes, I mean, there's no care, if the body may not be ready, if that foot can't handle pointe shoes, but since that person is in the EAAE, they have to do pointe shoes. And many schools apply it because they don't have students in free education. Because the state gives you 7000 euros per child per year. The DGEST, there's an agreement. And I don't want it. Schools have EAE and free education. If we're strong in EAE, and in free education, you're weak, hold on to the DGEST. That's why I tell you it's important to stay. Because I'm in free education and I have 100 students, understand? Without support from the DGEST, without the student having their 7000 euros to dissolve in training. And we build them and we do them and we're here standing with an EAE. That starts to happen... I have Ana Manjericao here who does it, in the EAE, the girls start to go but nobody gives up from here. So...

Matteo: Do you offer discounts for those who stay longer with you?

Suly: No, the discount is for those who take more classes. The more classes, the less you pay for each. And if you have a sibling, they both get discounts too. If you have family, discount too. What's happening is that I observe people who don't have financial capacity and I give them small opportunities, for example, if I think you have talent and potential, I'll offer you classes, you pay for contemporary and Sevillanas, and I offer you ballet and top group classes. That happens quite a bit. When I bet on talent. But I think it's also a mission. I don't tell this to anyone because I'm not interested. Because everyone will want it. That's more from my perspective. I have between 10 and 15 out of 160-something. And that represents some money for the school.

Daniela: What is your recruitment process for teachers?

Suly: They send their CV. I receive CVs almost every day.

Daniela: Do you have a form on the website to send it?

Suly: I have. Many CVs. Then an interview.

Daniela: What would be the criteria for choosing a teacher?

Suly: First, their training, where they come from, depends on the modality. I don't want a ballet teacher, now a hip-hop teacher is not something, it depends.

Matteo: Usually, do people call you, message you?

Suly: They always call. To ask things. The parents, not the children.

Daniela: Do you have any strategy to attract new clients?

Suly: The change of a new phone. And a digital marketing course. To understand several things, to understand my avatar, the best copies, the right client, who my client is. When you have those things clear, you start understanding many things and how to communicate, but I still lack many things, especially time to dedicate. I think that was the first strategy. The second one, in every show, no one new comes or they come but what happens is that the student who was already doing Sevillanas and Latinas, now also wants Hip-Hop. That's for sure and seen like that it's like a

new student. That's why I tell you to multiply 164 students by a minimum of 2. And it will give you the number.

Daniela: The average is what? 3 modalities?

Suly: Yes, the average is 3. One modality is very rare. They start with one.

Daniela: If you could provide me with the accesses later. Partnerships...

Suly: There's a partner that's at least for the next 10 years. Who is the partner who remodeled my entire academy. They did it very cheaply. Blocosystems. They are now the partner of Century 21 who will make the modular house for Rock in Rio.

Daniela: Do you have any different goals for your festival this year?

Suly: My festival always means more people. I started with one day, now I'm at two days and this year it's going to be three days. November 1st, 2nd, and 3rd. The growth is also that. I started at the Maristas in Carcavelos doing the festival. Now I'm at the Estoril Casino producing the event. And a very good thing I had at the Estoril Casino, the workshops are in the Estoril Casino box. No one does that. The dancer has a class for 1 hour with the teacher in the box. So, this year. Next year I don't know. Because that's very difficult and not profitable. Profitable is to have a show at the casino. With ticket sales and those things, now a workshop isn't.

Daniela: Do you also have statistics for your sales?

Suly: That's very easy, yes. From the tickets. This year I sold out. The first year I sold out the casino 3 times. What this means, sold out, more places opened up, sold out, more places opened up, and sold out again.

Daniela: Do you repeat the same show twice?

Suly: It's rare. That's a good question. A very good question. That's what my father has always told me. If I do it twice, but not in full. Right now, on April 25th, I did a show and I made a selection of the best of the best.

Daniela: But with all that theater link...

Suly: That's unrepeatable. This year the strategy was to lower ticket prices and I sold out. Normally a ticket for one of our shows goes from 13 euros to 20 euros and this year it didn't go over 15 euros. And it sold out. I imagine that those who went to buy said, hey, I can buy 4 instead of 3. Or I can invite so and so because this is affordable. I put the tickets at 12.50€ and 15 euros and the revenue was much higher than when it was more expensive and not sold out. It was a marketing option I used and it went well and I was scared.

Daniela: And all the events you do are with the top group or how does it work?

Suly: They are selected, for example on April 25th, some groups went, it was Latinas 4, Latinas 5, and Ballet 3 and 4, a couple doing a bachata, and now on the 18th, Sevillanas 3.

Daniela: And how is the contact with you for those events? Do they contact you?

Suly: The one on the 18th was combined because there's a strategy behind it. But normally they contact me to invite me.

Daniela: But is there payment?

Suly: Some do, some don't. Today they called me to do an event with some models but they didn't want to pay so I didn't go because I'm starting to be selective. If they don't pay, the event has to be quite interesting. For example, the one we're going to tomorrow, we're going to a bullring to dance in Azambuja, flamenco, that's interesting. It's several flamenco schools but at least I asked for the gas. And we do the show and interact with the others and see what's going on.

Daniela: And do you feel in any way any return from those events?

Suly: You don't feel it physically. You feel it online. You start gaining more followers and above all, online, whoever sees you and says, these people are everywhere. That's the feeling you pass on. My own students tell me, I don't know how Suly has time. I have time, I organize myself and do my things. But whoever sees me has the feeling that I do many things and at school too, that I'm in many places. And that we go to many events. And that gives a sense that these people are on the rise and they are.

Daniela: You open at 6 until 9, right?

Suly: I open at 5:30 but classes start at 6 until 9:00/9:30. Mondays and Thursdays until 9:30.

Daniela: Do you not have Saturdays?

Suly: On Saturdays, I have the intensive Sevillanas course for adults. It's the only thing I have for adults. I created a course where they could come, every other week, to have classes with me. And let me tell you about the choreographic party. It's an event that engages quite a few students. The choreographic party is the final event, where the kids create their own choreographies. We produce the event, the theater, the lights, and they create and select everything from the costumes, the music, who they want to dance with, whether they want to dance a bachata, if they want to dance ballet... They have that space. That space is for them. Kids have a lot of imagination, and there's a lot of repressed things that they can't do, that the teacher can't achieve because the teacher is thinking about the group. Many good things come out, which I can later use. I say, I liked this solo, let's take it to this show. And they represent the academy with their dances. And that's the best I can do for a student. This year will be the fifth edition. In July. This year what I'm going to do strategically, on July 14th in Amadora and on July 27th here in Cascais, in Criarte. In September, classes start, in November, I have the Cascais festival. It started being called the dance festival of San Domingos de Rana, nowadays the council asked me to call it the Cascais Dance Festival. The board didn't want to, it was a hassle, and now it's called the International Youth Dance Festival of San Domingos Cascais. It has a very big name, but the acronym shortens it. Then in December, open classes, for parents, to show them the first term. This place fills up with parents. We open the classes because parents don't attend classes. In April the show,

at the casino. In May, enrollment renewal, in July the ATL, in July the choreographic party. Because that keeps the student quite loyal here.

Then I also have weddings. Normally I have 4 or 5 weddings per year. Easily over all these years, I've done a hundred and something weddings. In various ways, with the company, me choreographing for the couples.

Daniela: With the company, how is it?

Suly: The company dances at the wedding. I've had the company dancing with a bride, making the entrance with a bride who studied at the Spanish Institute. Those rehearsals, since I don't have fixed schedules here, I set up a dance studio in my garage. During the week, I adapt to the couples, and they to me.

Daniela: Do you promote that on social media?

Suly: Yes. I happened to post it on my personal account.

Daniela: And do you budget depending on what they want?

Suly: It's always the same. I guarantee you that with that, in 5 classes, you can do it. And if you can't, I offer you the sixth. I have that fixed price.

Daniela: And is that price published?

Suly: No. That's upon inquiry. But I practice the same for everyone. It's €350.